DZOTOBILCHAY

Maya Tamales with Chaya and Eggs in a Roasted Tomato Sauce

makes 8 tamales

Dzotobilchay is a tamal from the Yucatán Peninsula made using masa mixed with chaya leaves. Chaya is a perennial tropical shrub that produces nutrient-dense leaves that taste like spinach. (In fact, chaya is sometimes called tree spinach or Maya spinach.)

Today, you'll often see dzotobilchay wrapped in banana leaves, but I use corn husks here. Otherwise, with its pepitas and hard-boiled egg filling and pan-roasted tomato sauce, this dish is fairly traditional.

TAMALES

¼ cup pepitas

4 duck eggs

Sea salt

8 ounces chaya leaves, lamb's quarters, or spinach

½ cup duck fat

1 pound Fresh Masa (page 28) or use masa harina (see chart, page 27)

8 dried corn husks for tamales, soaked overnight, plus more for the pot

SAUCE

2 tablespoons avocado or sunflower oil, plus more for brushing

½ small white onion, cut into 6 wedges

1 garlic clove, unpeeled

1 jalapeño, halved lengthwise and seeded

5 plum tomatoes, halved lengthwise

1 teaspoon cider vinegar

Sea salt

Make the tamales: In a large dry skillet, toast the pepitas over medium heat for about 2 minutes, or until they start to darken. Transfer to a food processor.

When the seeds are cool, pulse them until they are coarsely ground. Scrape into a bowl.

Set up a bowl of ice and water and place it near the stove. In a medium saucepan, bring several inches of water to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to medium-low so the water simmers and carefully lower the eggs into the pot, making sure they are submerged. Cook for 10 minutes. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the eggs to the ice bath. Let cool, then peel the eggs. Leave the water at a simmer.

Chop the hard-boiled eggs and add them to the bowl with the pepitas. Season with salt and toss to combine.

Add the chaya leaves to the simmering water and cook for about 1 minute, until bright green. Drain the leaves in a colander and run them under cool water. Squeeze out as much of the liquid as possible and coarsely chop the leaves.

In a bowl, using an electric mixer, beat the duck fat on high speed until fluffy. Add the masa, a little at a time, until incorporated. Scrape the chopped greens into the masa and stir until evenly distributed.

Arrange 1 husk on a work surface, ribbed-side down, with the narrow end pointing away from you. Using a ¼-cup measure, scoop dough into the center of the husk. Use a large rounded spoon to create a well in the dough, leaving a ½-inch border of husk. Measure out about 3 tablespoons of the pepita/egg filling and arrange it in the well.

Fold in the long sides of the husk, overlapping them to enclose the filling. Fold the narrow end toward you, over the tamal; it will be open at the wide end. Stand the tamal, open-end up, in a steamer insert. Repeat with the remaining husks, dough, and filling.

Cover the tamales with more corn husks or parchment paper.

(recipe continues)

Fill the bottom of the steamer with water to come no higher than where the bottom of the steamer insert will be. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Reduce the heat to low. Add the steamer insert, cover the pot, and steam the tamales for 1½ hours. Remove one of the tamales from the steamer. If it feels firm, check inside. If it looks shiny and wet or you see a lot of residue sticking to the husk when you pull it away, continue cooking for up to 30 minutes longer. Otherwise, remove from the steamer and let cool for 15 minutes. The masa will continue to firm up during this time.

While the tamales cook, make the sauce: Heat a comal or heavy skillet over medium-high heat. Lightly brush it with some oil. Add the onion wedges, garlic, and jalapeño and cook, turning frequently, for 5 to 8 minutes, or until charred in spots. Let the garlic clove cool, then peel and transfer to a blender. Remove the stem from the jalapeño and transfer to the blender along with the onion.

Add the tomatoes skin-sides down to the pan and cook for about 2 minutes, or until blistered on the bottom. Flip and cook them for about 30 seconds, just until the flesh side is blistered in spots.

Transfer the tomatoes to the blender and pulse until nearly smooth but with some texture.

In a skillet, heat the 2 tablespoons oil over medium heat, until just warmed through. Carefully stir in the pureed sauce (it may steam and bubble up) and cook for 3 to 5 minutes, until slightly thickened and darker. Stir in the vinegar. Taste and season with salt.

Serve the tamales with the roasted tomato sauce.